

How to Replace a \$1M/Year Marketing Team with a Single AI Tool

The AIMA Method — Manual 1: Direct Response Advertising, Fulfilled with ToMarket.io

Bowsky

The Team You're About to Replace

Here's what it costs to hire the people who make and run ads for a business. Seven seats. This is the whole department — the folks who design the images, write the scripts, write the copy, shoot and cut the video, buy the media, and sit at the top deciding what to do.

In-house ad team, base salaries at low, medium, and high market rates

Role	Low	Medium	High
Graphic designer	\$55K	\$70K	\$85K
Ad script writer	\$65K	\$83K	\$100K
Copywriter	\$65K	\$80K	\$95K
Video editor	\$65K	\$83K	\$100K
Video producer / videographer	\$75K	\$98K	\$120K
CMO	\$170K	\$250K	\$420K
Media buyer	\$62K	\$83K	\$105K
Total base payroll	\$557K	\$746K	\$1.025M

Base payroll isn't what they cost you. Add benefits and employer costs — payroll taxes, health insurance, equipment, software seats, the desk they sit at — which runs roughly 43% on top of salary.

Cost level	Base payroll	Benefits and employer costs	Total annual cost
Low	\$557,000	\$239,000	\$796,000
Medium	\$746,000	\$320,000	\$1,066,000
High	\$1,025,000	\$439,000	\$1,464,000

Call it a million dollars a year for a middle-of-the-road team in a mid-sized market. And that's before they spend a single dollar on actual ads — this is just the people.

Now here's the other number. ToMarket.io, the platform this manual runs on, charges \$499 a month for the plan that makes your ads and runs them — about \$6,000 a year — plus the credits you spend generating creative. Budget it honestly at around \$500 a month all-in and you're at roughly \$6,000 a year against \$1,066,000. It never takes a percentage of your ad spend. It runs inside your own Meta and Google accounts. And it does the work of six of those seven seats around the clock.

Six of seven. Not seven. That's the part every "AI replaces your team" pitch lies about, and I won't. The tool replaces the hands. It draws, writes, edits, shoots, and buys. It does not replace the head — the seat at the top of that table, the one making \$250,000 to decide *what* to sell, *to whom*, and *whether it's working*. That seat is now yours. This manual is the training for it.

I've paid for that whole table more than once. When I built my lead-gen company from \$2,000 a week to \$108,000 a week, I had designers, writers, editors, and buyers on payroll, and I was the CMO whether I

wanted to be or not. I've had \$100M revenue years and I still spend six figures a month on my own ads. Everything those people knew how to do is now inside the software. What they *couldn't* do — what I had to do myself — is the judgment. Which offer. Which angle. Which ad passes and which goes back. What the numbers mean on Monday morning. Advertising isn't hard to get good at. It's expensive to get good at. You just skipped the expensive part. Don't skip the judgment part.

One more thing before we start. If you're an AIMA operator reading this to fulfill for clients rather than for your own business, everything here applies identically — you're sitting in the CMO seat for someone else's company. The economics are why the whole model works: a local business owner would pay a million dollars for this department and can't, so they pay you about \$3,000 a month, and you deliver it for about \$500. Hold that thought; it comes back in Part E.

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Part A — The seats you’re replacing

1. Seat by seat: what each person did all day, and what does it now

Walk the table with me. I want you to understand exactly what each of these people produced, because that’s what you now have to know how to *judge*.

Graphic designer (\$70K). Made the static image ads — the offer graphic, the before-and-after, the branded post — and sized them for every placement. In ToMarket.io this is the image side of **Ad Studio**. You add the business by link or upload, pick how to build (from a link, from the brand kit, from a template, from competitor ads, or from market research), and it generates a set of image ads as drafts in your library. The designer’s week is now a few minutes of previews.

Ad script writer (\$83K) and copywriter (\$80K). Two seats, one job: the words. The script writer wrote what the person in the video says; the copywriter wrote the headline, the body text, the call to action, and the Google search ad lines. ToMarket.io writes all of it. The **Instant** flow takes a link or an offer and builds five ads, the audience, and the copy in two steps. Ad Studio writes the video scripts and puts them in front of you to approve before anything renders. Your job moved from writing to editing — and editing is judgment, which is Part C.

Video editor (\$83K) and video producer/videographer (\$98K). The two most expensive creative seats after the CMO, because video is slow and video is what wins on Meta. The videographer shot it; the editor cut it, captioned it, and versioned it for Reels, Stories, and feed. Ad Studio makes the video without a camera. Eight formats — street interview, creator UGC, song ad, mascot vlog, podcast ad, story ad, product hype, explainer — with hundreds of avatars and “style worlds” from photoreal to 3D to anime. You pick the format, the avatar, the concept, and the caption style; you approve the script and each scene’s opening frame; it renders ad-ready at 30 or 60 seconds with captions burned in. Under the hood it routes each job to the right engine automatically (it names Anthropic, GPT Image 2.5, Gemini, Kling, Seedance, ElevenLabs, Whisper, and HeyGen). You don’t need to know which model made what. You need to know whether the first three seconds will stop a thumb.

Media buyer (\$83K). The person who lived inside Meta Ads Manager and Google Ads all day: launching campaigns, watching cost per lead, pausing losers, feeding winners, adjusting budgets, fixing the pixel. This is the seat ToMarket.io was built to replace first. Its **IF/THEN rules engine** runs the campaigns on full autopilot, on rules built by a team that managed over \$500,000 a day in ad spend. When it takes a spending action, it calls Meta or Google directly and confirms the action happened — their phrase is “confirmed, not merely claimed.” Every action shows on your dashboard in real time, and **ToMarket Review** lets you see and approve every move before it’s made if you want that level of control. Part D is how you manage the buyer who never sleeps.

Six seats. Roughly \$497,000 in base salary at the medium level, closer to \$711,000 fully loaded. Replaced by software that costs about what one of them spent on parking.

2. The one seat that doesn’t go away

The CMO — chief marketing officer — is the person who decides. Not what color the button is. What the business is selling this month, to whom, at what offer, with what budget, and whether last week’s numbers mean “scale it” or “kill it.” At \$250,000 a year that’s the most expensive seat at the table, and

it's the one no tool sits in, because the decisions depend on knowing the business.

That's you now. Here's what the seat actually requires, and it's the outline of the rest of this manual:

- Know the business's numbers cold — what a customer is worth, what the margin is, how many they can handle.
- Decide the offer and the angle. Everything downstream is built from that.
- Approve or send back what the creative team (now Ad Studio) produces, against a standard.
- Set the budget and the goal, launch, and then have the discipline to let the buyer (now the rules engine) work.
- Read the dashboard every week and know what "good" looks like for this industry.
- Tell the owner — or yourself — the truth about whether it's making money.

None of that takes years anymore. It takes this manual and a few weeks of reps. Let's get you in the seat.

Part B — Sitting in the CMO seat: before you launch anything

3. The kickoff: knowing the business better than they do

A CMO who doesn't know what a customer is worth is guessing with someone else's money. So the first thing you do — before you open the software — is collect the numbers. If this is your own business, do this exercise on yourself and be honest. If you're an AIMA operator, this is the kickoff call with the owner.

Definitions first, because I define everything the first time:

- **Average customer value:** what one new customer is worth, on the first sale or over the time they stay. A roofer might be \$12,000 a job. A restaurant might be \$40 a visit but come back fifty times.
- **Gross margin:** what the business keeps from a sale after the direct cost of delivering it. A med spa selling a \$600 treatment that costs \$150 in product and room time has a 75% margin. You need this to know break-even later.
- **Speed-to-lead:** how fast a new lead gets contacted after it comes in. Section 4. It will make or break your results and it has nothing to do with the ads.
- **Business Manager:** Meta's control panel where the Facebook Page, Instagram, ad account, and payment method live. You need access. Same idea for the Google Ads account.

The kickoff, word for word:

"Before I build anything, I need to understand this business better than the competitors understand theirs. Some of these questions are about money — be straight with me, because I can't do this well if I'm guessing.

When someone becomes a new customer, what are they worth on the first sale? ... Do they come back? Over a year, what's a good customer worth? ...

Of that first sale, roughly how much do you keep after direct costs? Ballpark is fine. ...

How many new customers a month could you actually handle right now? If I flooded you tomorrow, where does it break? ...

When a lead comes in — a form or a call — who answers? How fast? What happens at 6 p.m. or on a Saturday? ...

Hours, and the area you actually serve? ...

What are you offering right now to get someone in the door? ...

Have you run ads before? What happened, what did you spend, do you still have the accounts? ...

I'll need access to Meta Business Manager, the Facebook Page and Instagram, Google Ads if it exists, and the website. Plus the logo, any photos or video you've got, and where your best reviews live."

Kickoff collection checklist

- ☐ Average customer value — first sale
- ☐ Average customer value — lifetime / annual
- ☐ Gross margin (%)

- ☐ Monthly capacity for new customers, and where it breaks
- ☐ Who handles inbound leads, how fast, after-hours coverage
- ☐ Business hours
- ☐ Service area
- ☐ Current offer(s) and pricing
- ☐ Past ad history: platforms, spend, results, account access
- ☐ Access to Meta Business Manager / Page / Instagram
- ☐ Access to Google Ads (or note one must be created)
- ☐ Website URL and who controls it
- ☐ Logo and brand assets
- ☐ Photos and video of the real business, staff, work
- ☐ Where the best reviews live

4. Setting expectations in writing (and the speed-to-lead problem)

More marketing relationships die in the first thirty days than at any other time, and almost never because the ads were bad. They die because somebody expected something different than what happened. A real CMO manages that before it happens. Write it down and send it.

The first 30 days are a testing period. The platform tries several creatives, angles, and audiences and needs real spend and real results before it knows what works. Early numbers bounce. Say so before it happens.

What a lead is. A person who gave contact information asking to hear from the business — a form fill or a call. Not a customer. You're responsible for leads at a good cost. Turning them into customers is shared, and most of it is on the business's side.

Speed-to-lead. The most important paragraph in the note. The foundational research is the 2007 MIT / InsideSales.com Lead Response Management Study by Dr. James Oldroyd of MIT Sloan — three years of data, six companies, over 15,000 leads and 100,000 call attempts. The odds of *contacting* a lead if you call in five minutes versus thirty drop by 100 times; the odds of *qualifying* it drop by 21 times. The follow-up, Oldroyd, McElheran and Elkington's "The Short Life of Online Sales Leads" in *Harvard Business Review* (March 2011), audited 2,241 US companies: average response time among those who replied at all was 42 hours, firms responding within an hour were nearly seven times as likely to qualify the lead as those who waited even one more hour and more than 60 times as likely as those who waited a day, and 23% never responded. Say it plainly: *I can send a perfect lead, and if someone calls it back tomorrow afternoon, it's dead. Someone has to be calling these people in minutes.* If that can't happen, flag it now.

Whose accounts these run in. The campaigns run in the business's own Meta and Google ad accounts, on the business's payment method. ToMarket.io operates inside those accounts. The business owns the account, the pixel data, the history.

Two separate money buckets. The management cost (the software, and if you're an operator, your fee) and the **ad budget** — the money that goes to Meta and Google to buy the actual impressions and clicks. Nobody takes a cut of the ad budget. Make this unmistakable.

How to set an ad budget. Work backward from customer value and capacity. If a customer is worth

\$12,000 and they can take ten more a month, they can afford real budget. If a customer's worth \$80 on thin margins, go lean. As a floor, you want enough daily spend to produce a handful of leads a day so the platform has data — for most local lead gen that's somewhere around \$50-\$100 a day to start, tuned once you see cost per lead against the business's numbers. The right budget is the one where each lead costs less than the profit from the customers those leads become. Section 14 makes that exact.

5. Setting up the department in ToMarket.io

Now you open the software. Creating an account is free; you pay for the workspaces you run.

A **workspace** is one brand or business. One workspace per brand or client — and if you run several, one bill and one shared credit pool across all of them, each workspace isolated with its tokens encrypted. Create the workspace. That's the department's building.

Inside it, connect the accounts. ToMarket.io runs inside the business's own Meta and Google ad accounts and says you can connect them "in minutes." Build the **brand kit** — logo, colors, assets from the kickoff — which Ad Studio draws from. Confirm the exact click-paths for connecting Business Manager and Google Ads and for setting up the brand kit in your account; the site names the capabilities but doesn't publish a step-by-step.

Two terms:

- **Pixel:** the tracking code on the website that tells Meta (and Google's equivalent tag) what happened after the click — landed, filled the form, called. Without it, the platforms can't optimize and you can't measure.
- **Instant form:** a lead form that opens inside Facebook or Instagram without the person leaving the app. ToMarket.io can build one as part of the campaign.

ToMarket.io shows **pixel health** on the dashboard so, in its words, you never need to open Meta Events Manager. Before launch it must be healthy. If it isn't, that's the first thing you fix.

Setup checklist (confirm exact steps in your account)

- ☐ Workspace created
- ☐ Meta connected (Business Manager, Page, Instagram, ad account)
- ☐ Google Ads connected
- ☐ Brand kit built
- ☐ Pixel / tracking healthy on the dashboard
- ☐ Payment method is the business's, in the business's accounts
- ☐ Slack connected if you'll use it for approvals (Section 17)

Part C — Directing the creative team you no longer have

6. The offer: the CMO's first and biggest decision

This is the decision the \$250,000 seat exists for. Get the offer right and mediocre creative still pulls leads. Get it wrong and the best creative on earth can't save you. Alex Hormozi's order of importance in *\$100M Offers* is market, then offer, then persuasion. You picked the market when you picked the business. The offer is yours.

Hormozi's value equation: $\text{Value} = (\text{Dream Outcome} \times \text{Perceived Likelihood of Achievement}) \div (\text{Time Delay} \times \text{Effort \& Sacrifice})$. Raise the top, shrink the bottom. For a local business:

- **Dream outcome:** not "dental cleaning" — a smile they're not embarrassed by. Not "HVAC repair" — a cool house tonight.
- **Perceived likelihood:** reviews, guarantees, "we've done 4,000 of these," before-and-afters.
- **Time delay:** "same-day appointments," "we'll be there tomorrow."
- **Effort and sacrifice:** "free estimate," "no obligation," "we handle the paperwork."

Lead-gen offer vs. direct sale. A lead-gen offer trades something low-friction — free estimate, \$49 exam, a quote — for contact info, and the selling happens after by phone or in person. A direct sale asks for the purchase in the ad. Dentists, roofers, law firms, med spas: lead-gen, because the sale is too big or too personal for a feed. Restaurants and a gym's trial class can go closer to direct.

Offer templates by niche (starting points — sharpen with the real numbers):

- Dentist: "\$79 new-patient exam, X-rays, and cleaning" / "Free Invisalign consult + \$500 off."
- Med spa: "First Botox visit \$9/unit" / "Free skin consult + \$100 toward your first treatment."
- HVAC: "Free system estimate + \$89 tune-up" / "No-cost second opinion on any quote."
- Roofer: "Free roof inspection + drone report" / "Storm damage? Free inspection, we handle the insurance."
- Restaurant: "Free appetizer with two entrées this week" / "Kids eat free Tuesdays."
- Gym: "7-day free trial + free PT session" / "\$1 first month."
- Law firm: "Free case review, no fee unless we win."
- Real estate: "Free instant home valuation" / "Free list of off-market homes in [area]."
- Auto shop: "Free brake inspection" / "\$49 full synthetic oil change + multi-point check."

The brief is the job description you hand the team. ToMarket.io builds from a link or offer details. Instant takes that input and produces five ads, the audience, and the copy, with everything landing paused so nothing spends until you say go. What you type is what the department builds from. Brief it like you're briefing a sharp new writer who's never met this business.

Fill-in-the-blank offer brief

- Business: [name], a [niche] in [city], serving [area].
- The offer: [exact offer].
- Who it's for: [ideal customer, one line].

- Dream outcome: [what they really want].
- Why us / proof: [review count, years, guarantee, credentials].
- How fast: [same-day, this week].
- The ask (CTA): [book, call, get a quote, claim the deal].
- What happens after they respond: [who calls, how fast].
- Hard rules: [service area limits, anything the business won't say, compliance words to avoid].

7. Who the ads are talking to

The same offer written two ways wins or loses depending on what the reader already knows. Eugene Schwartz, *Breakthrough Advertising* (1966): five stages of awareness — unaware, problem aware, solution aware, product aware, most aware. Where the reader sits decides what the ad is allowed to say.

For local, the split you care about is the channel. **Meta is interruption.** Nobody opens Instagram looking for a roofer; you're catching them mid-scroll, problem aware at best. The ad has to name the problem and stop the thumb before it mentions the offer. **Google Search is intent.** Someone typing "emergency roof repair near me" is solution or most aware. Don't convince them they have a problem. Show up, look credible, make it easy to act.

What this changes in what you approve: on Meta, opening frames that lead with the viewer's problem or dream, not the logo. On Google, copy that matches the exact search and gets out of the way. Same offer, two jobs.

8. Research the writers used to do

Good ads come from what customers actually say. Claude Hopkins in *Scientific Advertising* (1923) insisted writers research the product before writing and treated advertising as salesmanship that had to be measured. Three sources, in order:

The reviews. Five-star ones for the exact words people use about the dream outcome ("I finally smile in photos again"). One- and two-star reviews of *competitors* for the pains people are running from ("waited three weeks and they never called back"). Those phrases become hooks.

The Meta Ad Library. A free public tool where you see every ad any advertiser is running. Search the competitors in town. An ad that's run for months is probably working. Note offers, angles, formats. That's Schwartz's market sophistication — how many similar claims the market has already heard.

ToMarket.io's competitor and market inputs. Ad Studio builds from market research or from competitors directly — name them and it turns the best ads they run into reusable templates for your offer. Your manual review tells you which competitors to name and whether what the tool surfaces matches reality.

9. Ad Studio: the designer, the writers, the editor, and the videographer in one room

This is where five salaries turn into a few credits, and where your CMO judgment is worth the most. Everything Ad Studio makes lands in your library as a draft. Previews cost a credit; you spend the real credits only unlocking the winners you approve.

How it builds. Images: add the business by link or upload, pick a build method (link, brand kit, template, competitor ads, market research), get a set of drafts. Video: pick a format, pick an avatar, choose actor, concept, caption style; approve the script and every scene's opening frame; it renders ad-ready with captions at 30 or 60 seconds, into the library, ready to launch into a new campaign or one you already run.

Which formats fit which businesses:

- Trust-driven niches (dental, med spa, law): creator UGC and street-interview styles read as real people.
- Visual before-and-after niches (roofing, remodeling, auto detailing, med spa): image ads and product-hype video that show the transformation.
- Fun, high-frequency local niches (restaurants, gyms): mascot vlog, song ad, story ads.
- Explainer for any offer that needs a sentence of setup.

Request a spread. John Caples, *Tested Advertising Methods*: one ad can sell many times what a near-identical one sells — the game is testing to find the outlier. Don't approve one ad. Instant builds five at once for exactly this reason. Several hooks, a couple of formats, image and video.

The opening-frame standard. David Ogilvy, *Confessions of an Advertising Man* (1963): "On the average, five times as many people read the headline as read the body copy. When you have written your headline, you have spent eighty cents out of your dollar." On social video the headline is the first three seconds. The metric is **hook rate** — three-second views divided by impressions. On Meta, roughly 25% is average, 30%+ strong, 40%+ elite; under about 20% and the first frame is being scrolled past. You approve *for* that number. Does this frame stop a thumb? A logo doesn't. A person mid-sentence saying something surprising does. Send back any opener that leads with the company.

The copy checklist. Two structures to recognize: **AIDA** (Attention, Interest, Desire, Action; E. St. Elmo Lewis, 1898) and **PAS** (Problem, Agitate, Solve), which Dan Kennedy called the most reliable sales formula ever invented. Most good local ads are PAS.

- ☐ Leads with the customer's problem or dream, not the company name
- ☐ Follows PAS or AIDA — a hook, a reason to care, a clear ask
- ☐ Talks about *them*, not *us*
- ☐ Specific, not vague ("\$79 exam," "booked in 48 hours")
- ☐ Has proof — a number, a guarantee, a real review
- ☐ The CTA matches what actually happens next
- ☐ Nothing that violates platform policy or the brief's hard rules

CTA and instant form alignment. If the ad promises "\$79 new-patient exam," the instant form and the first words on the callback must both be about the \$79 exam. When ad, form, and follow-up say the same thing, cost per lead drops and leads stop feeling like strangers.

Credits discipline. Preview widely, approve narrowly. Your ~\$500 a month is mostly credits; unlocking everything is how that number creeps.

Approved vs. sent back (dentist).

Sent back: opening frame is the practice logo. Copy: "Smith Family Dental — serving [town] for 20 years.

Call us today!” Leads with the company, no hook, no offer.

Approved: opening frame is a real patient mid-sentence, caption on screen: “I hadn’t smiled in photos for years.” Copy: “Hate your smile? New patients get a full exam, X-rays, and cleaning for \$79 this month — most people book same-week. Tap to grab a spot.” Problem, dream, speed, offer, ask.

10. The Google side of the same campaign

ToMarket.io runs Google alongside Meta, and for local it’s often your highest-intent leads. The format is the **responsive search ad (RSA)** — since Google retired fixed-text ads in June 2022, it’s the only search ad format. You supply up to 15 headlines and 4 descriptions and Google assembles the combination that fits each search.

- **Headline coverage.** Distinct angles: service (“Emergency Roof Repair”), location (“Roofers in [Town]”), offer (“Free Roof Inspection”), proof (“500+ 5-Star Reviews”), call to action (“Call for Same-Day Service”). Not fifteen ways to say one thing.
- **Pinning restraint.** Pinning forces a headline into a slot. Over-pinning collapses the combinations Google can test. Pin only what *must* appear.
- **Call and location assets.** On, always, for local. A searcher with a problem right now taps to call before they fill a form.

Review Google copy against intent, not against your Meta creative.

11. Launch

Three decisions and a checklist.

Goal mode. ToMarket.io offers three: optimize a set budget, scale as long as your KPIs are met, or hit a set number of conversions. New campaign, testing period: set-budget. Move to scale once cost per lead holds where it needs to (Section 16).

Starting budget. The number from Section 4, defensible from the business’s own economics.

ToMarket Review. Puts every action the platform wants to take in front of you first, at the level of control you choose, and confirms with Meta or Google that the action actually happened. First campaign, first couple of weeks: see what it’s doing before it does it. Loosen as you trust the rhythm. Confirm the exact review levels in your account.

Pre-launch checklist

- ☐ Pixel healthy
- ☐ Running in the business’s own accounts, their payment method
- ☐ Offer in the ad = instant form = callback script
- ☐ At least 3–4 distinct creatives approved
- ☐ Google RSA: full coverage, minimal pinning, call + location assets on
- ☐ Goal mode: set-budget
- ☐ Starting daily budget defensible from customer value and margin
- ☐ ToMarket Review at your chosen level

- ☐ Someone ready to call leads back in minutes
- ☐ Everything paused — nothing has spent yet

Part D — Managing the media buyer who never sleeps

12. What the rules engine does daily

A media buyer's day is dozens of small decisions: this ad's cost per lead is climbing, pause it; this audience is winning, give it more; spend is pacing fast, ease off. ToMarket.io's IF/THEN rules engine does this around the clock on a real media buyer's playbook — the site's point is that its AI isn't reading the ad platform's help docs, it's executing rules from a team that ran over \$500K a day. Every spending action is confirmed with Meta or Google and shown on your dashboard in real time.

Don't override it early. New CMOs see a scary number on day three and rip everything apart. The platforms need a learning period — real spend, real conversions — and so does the engine. Yank the wheel and you reset the learning every time. Set it up right, let it run through the testing window you promised. The fastest way to a bad result is not leaving it alone long enough to get a good one.

13. What you test by hand, and in what order

The engine optimizes what you gave it. *You* decide what new things enter the ring. In order:

1. **Offer.** The biggest lever. If leads are expensive, suspect the offer, not the headline.
2. **Angle / hook.** Same offer, different emotional door. This is where hook rate lives.
3. **Format.** Image vs. video, UGC vs. explainer.
4. **Headline.** Ogilvy's eighty cents.
5. **Audience.** Only after offer and creative are proven.
6. **Small stuff.** Button text, a caption. Last.

Weekly rhythm. Same day each week, introduce one or two new variants from Ad Studio into the running campaign and retire clear losers. Don't rebuild. Feed challengers to the champion.

14. Reading the dashboard like a CMO

The dashboard shows spend, leads, and blended cost per lead across every campaign, always current, plus pixel health.

- **CPM** — cost per 1,000 impressions. The price of attention.
- **CTR** — click-through rate. Whether the ad is compelling.
- **CPC** — cost per click.
- **CPL** — cost per lead. Usually your headline number.
- **CVR** — conversion rate: of those who clicked or saw the form, the share who became a lead.
- **ROAS** — return on ad spend: revenue ÷ spend. 3.0 means \$3 back per \$1.

Pixel first. If tracking is broken, every other number is a lie. Green, then everything else.

What “good” looks like — WordStream benchmarks. WordStream by LocaliQ analyzes thousands of real campaigns a year (their “averages” are medians). Meta, 2025 Facebook Ads Benchmarks (leads objective): overall CPL \$27.66, up 20.94% from \$22.87; CVR 7.72%; CPC \$1.92 — with an industry

spread from a few dollars to over seventy. Google, 2026 Google Ads Benchmarks: CPC \$5.42, CTR 6.64%, CVR 8.18%, CPL about \$66.69. Google leads cost more than Meta leads; that's the price of intent. Industry rows are in Section 19.

Break-even ROAS. $1 \div \text{gross margin}$. A 50% margin needs a 2.0 ROAS to break even; 40% needs 2.5; 25% needs 4.0; 70% needs about 1.43. Above break-even is profit. This is why you collected margin in the kickoff — without it you can tell the business it's getting leads, not that it's making money.

15. Troubleshooting by symptom

High CPM. Audience too narrow, creative being ignored, or a pricey season. Broaden the audience; get fresh creative in.

Low CTR / low hook rate. The first three seconds. New hooks and opening frames from Ad Studio.

Clicks but no leads. Ad and form don't match, or the offer isn't worth the contact info. Tighten the offer, simplify the form, make them say the same thing.

Leads, but they're junk. Usually a "More Volume" instant form catching low-intent taps. Meta's forms come in two types: More Volume (single screen, maximizes count) and Higher Intent (adds a review step). Switch to Higher Intent, add a qualifying question.

Leads, but nobody's calling them back. Not an ad problem — speed-to-lead. Show the timestamps. The campaign can be perfect and the business will still say "these don't convert."

Ad fatigue. A winner slowly dies from frequency. Your weekly rhythm should have replacements queued before it craters.

Pixel red. Stop-work order. Fix tracking before any other decision.

Policy disapprovals. Common in medical and legal. Soften the claim or remove the before/after that crosses the line; resubmit. Prevent it at approval time with the brief's hard rules.

Part E — Running the department

16. The weekly report and the monthly ROI conversation

A CMO reports up. If this is your own business, the report is to yourself and your partners, and it keeps you honest. If you're an operator, it's what keeps the account.

Three lines, same day every week.

Week of [date] — [business]

1. **Results:** [X] leads at [\$Y] each. Spend: [\$Z].
2. **What I did:** [tested a new hook / switched to higher-intent form / raised budget].
3. **What's next:** [what you're testing or watching].

Consistency beats depth. Same day, no exceptions.

Monthly ROI. Leads $\times$ close rate $\times$ average customer value, against spend, against break-even. "We spent \$2,000, generated 48 leads, closed 9, at \$1,200 each that's \$10,800 — break-even was 2.0, we're at 5.4." That sentence renews a contract by itself.

A slow first month. You said it would be a testing period. Remind them, but don't hide behind it — show what you learned and what you're changing.

Raising budget. Only when CPL holds at target *and* the business has capacity. Both. Then it's math: "Leads at \$34, you're closing them, you said you can take ten more a month — if we add \$30 a day we should see roughly [N] more. Turn it up?" This is also when you move goal mode from set-budget to scale-while-KPIs-hold.

"The offer isn't working." Don't say the offer is bad. "The market's telling us the \$99 price point isn't pulling. I want to test a stronger offer for two weeks." You're on their side against the market.

17. Running several departments at once (and the AIMA operator's math)

One CMO can now run marketing for many businesses, because the six seats under them are software. ToMarket.io is built for it: one workspace per client, one bill, one shared credit pool, each workspace isolated. The Slack integration brings updates and approvals to you, and the **Companion** answers questions about your account grounded in your data — it guides, it never acts for you.

A weekly schedule for 5-10 businesses. Batch by task, not by client:

- **Monday:** all weekly reports.
- **Tuesday-Wednesday:** creative day. Generate and approve new variants across every workspace. Preview widely, unlock narrowly.
- **Thursday:** numbers across every dashboard; troubleshooting from Section 15.
- **Friday:** budget and scaling decisions; monthly ROI calls that are due.
- **Throughout:** the engine runs the 90%; approvals in Slack as they come.

The operator's math. Go back to the table at the front of this manual. A local business owner would need about a million dollars a year to hire this department and can't. They can pay about \$3,000 a month for the result. You deliver it for about \$500 a month in software and credits, from a seat you can run for several businesses at once, a few hours a day each. That's roughly \$2,500 a month in gross margin per business, and the reason the whole AIMA model exists. The tool made the department cheap. The CMO seat — yours — is what the owner is actually paying for.

18. Mistakes that get a CMO fired

- **Overriding the rules engine on day three.** You reset the learning.
- **Launching with a weak offer.** No creative saves it.
- **Not defining "lead" up front.** If they think a lead is a customer, you've already lost.
- **Ignoring speed-to-lead.** The best campaign dies on an unanswered phone.
- **Going silent.** No weekly report and suddenly "I'm not sure this is working."
- **Approving one ad.** You need challengers.
- **Sloppy credits.** Unlocking everything.
- **Mismatched offer across ad, form, and callback.** Junk leads.
- **Scaling past capacity.** More leads than they can serve looks like your failure.
- **Blaming the ads, or the business.** When it's the follow-up, show the timestamps. When it's the offer, side with them against the market.

19. Niche quick-reference

Meta figures: WordStream 2025 Facebook Ads benchmarks (leads objective, CPL). Google: WordStream 2026 Google Ads benchmarks (CPC, CPL). Medians, directional; where a niche has no clean row, the closest published category is used and noted. Your job is to beat these, not match them.

Dentist / Dental. Offer: \$79 exam + X-rays + cleaning; free Invisalign/implant consult. Angles: embarrassment, fear of the dentist, same-week booking. Format: patient-testimonial UGC; before-and-after image. Meta CPL ~\$76.71 (highest in the report). Google ~\$8.00 CPC, ~\$72.97 CPL. Usually goes wrong: high CPL scares the owner — anchor on lifetime patient value.

Med Spa (proxy: Beauty & Personal Care / Health & Fitness). Offer: intro Botox pricing; free consult + credit. Angles: refreshed not "done," confidence, intro pricing. Format: UGC, before-and-after, product-hype. Meta CPL ~\$51. Google (Health & Fitness) ~\$6.17 CPC, ~\$67.36 CPL. Usually goes wrong: policy flags on skin claims.

HVAC (proxy: Home & Home Improvement). Offer: free estimate + \$89 tune-up; second opinion. Angles: comfort tonight, fear of the big bill, speed. Format: explainer; image with offer and phone. Meta CPL ~\$41.26. Google ~\$8.33 CPC, ~\$90.92 CPL. Usually goes wrong: seasonal swings — don't over-scale in a shoulder month.

Roofer (proxy: Home & Home Improvement). Offer: free inspection + drone report; storm/insurance angle. Format: before-and-after; explainer on the free inspection. Meta CPL ~\$41.26. Google ~\$8.33 CPC, ~\$90.92 CPL. Usually goes wrong: lead quality — Higher Intent form plus a qualifying question.

Restaurant. Offer: free appetizer with two entrées; kids eat free. Angles: cravings, local pride, this

week's deal. Format: mascot vlog, song ad, story ads. Meta CPL ~\$3.16 (lowest; CVR 18.25%). Google ~\$2.05 CPC, ~\$30.57 CPL. Usually goes wrong: cheap leads that don't visibly tie to revenue — track redemptions.

Gym (proxy: Health & Fitness / Personal Services). Offer: 7-day trial + PT session; \$1 first month. Angles: seasonal timing, community, low risk. Format: transformation UGC; energetic story/song ads. Meta CPL ~\$52.98. Google ~\$6.17-\$7.17 CPC, ~\$54.60-\$67.36 CPL. Usually goes wrong: trials that never convert — a follow-up and sales issue.

Law Firm. Offer: free case review; no fee unless we win (where allowed). Angles: reassurance, authority, proof. Format: explainer, testimonial UGC, clean image. Meta CPL ~\$18.17. Google ~\$9.87 CPC and ~\$131.63 CPL (highest of any industry). Usually goes wrong: Google is expensive and policy is strict — lean on Meta for volume.

Real Estate. Offer: free valuation; off-market list. Angles: curiosity about home value, fear of missing the right home. Format: image with the valuation hook; short explainer. Meta CPL ~\$16.61. Google ~\$3.22 CPC, ~\$102.51 CPL. Usually goes wrong: long time-to-close — set expectations on nurture.

Auto Repair. Offer: free brake inspection; \$49 synthetic oil change + check. Angles: safety, fear of a bigger bill, convenience. Format: explainer / image with offer and location. Meta CPL: no clean row published — track your own. Google ~\$4.35 CPC, ~\$29.96 CPL. Usually goes wrong: low-margin offers that only pay off if the counter upsells.

20. Sources

- Salary and employer-cost assumptions for the seven-seat in-house team — the figures in the opening tables are market-rate assumptions (low / medium / high) with benefits and employer costs modeled at roughly 43% of base payroll. Treat them as directional and check current ranges for your market.
- ToMarket.io — official website (Ad Studio formats, avatars, credits; Instant flow; goal modes; ToMarket Review; IF/THEN rules engine; dashboard and pixel health; Slack integration and Companion; one workspace per client, one bill, shared credit pool; pricing \$199 “Bring Your Own Ads” / \$499 “Make Your Own Ads”): <https://www.tomarket.io>
- Claude C. Hopkins, *Scientific Advertising* (1923): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Scientific_Advertising
- David Ogilvy, *Confessions of an Advertising Man* (1963): <https://www.goodreads.com/quotes/191457-on-the-average-five-times-as-many-people-read-the>
- Eugene M. Schwartz, *Breakthrough Advertising* (1966): <https://www.leadgen-economy.com/blog/five-stages-awareness-lead-generation/>
- Alex Hormozi, *\$100M Offers* (2021): <https://www.gregfaxon.com/blog/100m-offers-summary>
- Dan Kennedy — PAS: <http://www.nonprofitcopywriter.com/PAS-copywriting-formula.html>
- AIDA origin (E. St. Elmo Lewis, 1898): <https://copyadscontent.com/pas-framework-copywriting/>
- John Caples, *Tested Advertising Methods*: <https://www.scribd.com/document/830542329/John-Caples-Tested-Advertising-Methods>
- Meta instant forms — More Volume vs. Higher Intent: <https://adsuploader.com/blog/facebook-instant-form>
- Google responsive search ads guide: <https://www.stackmatix.com/blog/responsive-search-ads-guide>
- Hook rate benchmarks: <https://hawky.ai/blog/hook-rate>
- WordStream by LocaliQ — Facebook Ads Benchmarks 2025:

<https://www.wordstream.com/blog/facebook-ads-benchmarks-2025>

- WordStream by LocaliQ — Google Ads Benchmarks 2026: <https://www.wordstream.com/blog/2026-google-ads-benchmarks>
- MIT / InsideSales.com Lead Response Management Study (Oldroyd, 2007) and Oldroyd, McElheran & Elkington, "The Short Life of Online Sales Leads," *Harvard Business Review* (March 2011): <https://www.leadangel.com/blog/operations/lead-response-time/>
- Break-even ROAS = $1 \div \text{gross margin}$: <https://advertising.amazon.com/library/guides/ads-math>

A closing word. Six of the seven seats at that table are now software. The seventh is you. Feed it a real offer built from real research, approve for the hook, let the engine do the ninety percent, read the numbers against the benchmarks, and tell the truth every week. Do that and you're running a million-dollar marketing department for the price of a phone bill. Now go run the kickoff.